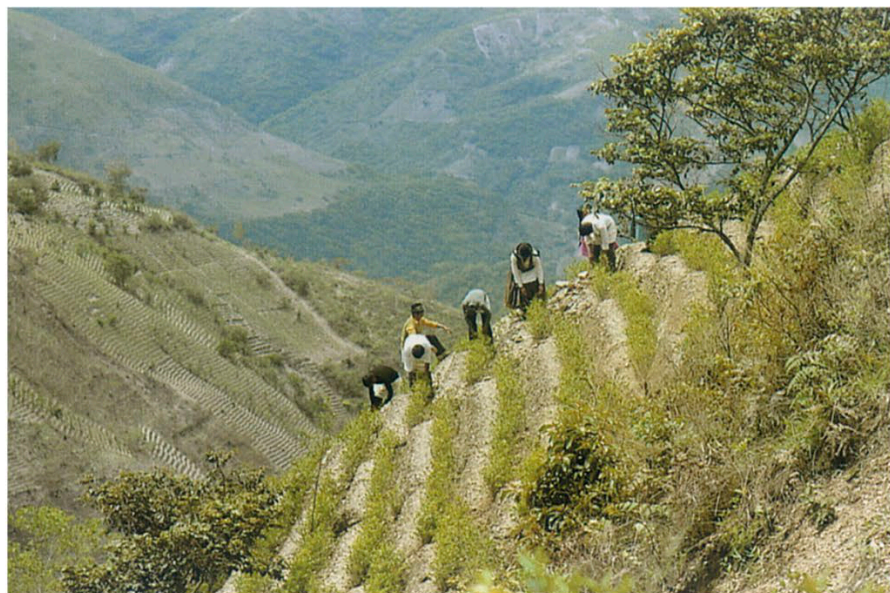




Coca harvest in Bolivia. The leaves are picked when they begin to curl. They have been used as a stimulant for centuries by the indigenous peoples of the Andes.

relationship that traditional peoples have with the plant world. Many different myths confirm coca's sacred and ancient origins in South America, and great ritual and significance is attached to the leaves, which, when mixed with lime and chewed, reduce appetite and increase endurance.

Many hallucinogenic plants are used within South American shamanistic societies, notably ayahuasca (*Banisteriopsis caapi*, p. 176). This powerful "medicine" enables the shaman (priest) to communicate with the spirit world and cure the patient's ill health.

The European Influence

In more westernized areas of South America, herbal medicine is often a blend of both Spanish and local traditions (as is also the case in Central America, see p. 48). Large herb markets exist in some cities, such as La Paz and Quito, which provide an astonishing variety of indigenous and European herbs. In Ecuadorian markets, for example, anise (*Pimpinella anisum*, p. 248), a digestive remedy for colic and cramps that originally came from the Mediterranean, is sold alongside unusual native medicines such as *arquitectura* (*Culcitium reflexum*), a diuretic and detoxifying herb traditionally used to treat toxicity and infections, including syphilis.

Research & New Hopes

Research into native herbs has led to the use of certain plants in conventional medicine. Brazilian investigation into pau d'arco (*Tabebuia impetiginosa*, p. 139) indicates significant therapeutic potential for fungal infections, inflammation of the cervix, HIV, and cancer. While pau d'arco's effectiveness in treating cancer is controversial, it is currently prescribed both by local doctors and in hospitals.

Research into herbal medicine is expanding, with hospital-based studies taking place in centers such as Belem in northeastern Brazil and Bogotá in Colombia. Such studies are important for the world as a whole. The locally based researchers, unlike most multinational drug companies, are willing to develop medicines based on simple extracts, which may ultimately prove more effective than the isolated constituents often used in conventional drugs.

Pau d'arco (*Tabebuia* spp., p. 139) is used as an anticancer remedy. It has long been used by indigenous Peruvian peoples to lower fever and reduce inflammation.

Pau d'arco tincture

Guarana (*Paullinia cupana*, p. 245) contains a natural stimulant with properties similar to caffeine. Roasted and ground guarana seeds are now widely used in the health food industry.

Soap bark (*Quillaja saponaria*, p. 260) is a traditional expectorant in Peru and Chile.

Pineapple (*Ananas comosus*, p. 167) is rich in vitamin C, and contains an enzyme that aids digestion. The juice is employed as a digestive tonic and a diuretic.